

Govt. Graduate College for Women, Baghbanpura, Lahore
BS Physics IV semester

Topic5:

Ethics

Short questions

1. Define ethics.

Ans. Ethics is a branch of philosophy that deals with the rightness and wrongness of an action. Through various ethical theories standards are sought that can help us to distinguish good actions from bad actions. These standards are necessary for progress of a society.

2. Is there a difference between morality and ethics?

Ans. Morals usually refer to personal beliefs influenced by factors such as society, culture, and individual experiences. Ethics are guidelines established by communities or specific groups outlining acceptable and unacceptable actions or behaviors.

3. What are the types of ethical theories?

Ans. The field of ethics, or moral philosophy, investigates theories that can systematically describe what makes acts right or wrong. Moral philosophy is usually divided into three categories: meta-ethics, applied ethics, and normative ethics.

4. What are meta-ethical theories?

Ans. Meta-ethics investigates where our moral values, language, and principles come from and what they mean; it is concerned with “what is morality?” rather than “what is moral?” for example a meta-ethical theory will not be concerned with which action can be considered honest rather it is about what it means to be honest.

5. What is meant by applied ethics?

Ans. Applied ethics seeks to apply philosophical tools to examine specific controversial issues and provide practical solutions to moral problems. Applied ethics has a very wide scope and is a part of almost all human endeavours in the form of medical ethics, environmental ethics, business ethics etc.

6. What are normative ethical theories?

Ans. Normative ethics investigates the moral standards that regulate right and wrong conduct. Theories within normative ethics include utilitarianism, consequentialism, contractualism, virtue ethics, and more.

7. What are the most common ethical theories?

Ans. Normative ethics as “theories of ethics that are concerned with the norms, standards or criteria that define principles of ethical behaviour” are the most common ethical theories. Examples of normative ethical theories are utilitarianism, Kantian duty-based ethics, and divine command theory.

8. What is emotivism?

Ans. Emotivism is an ethical theory that states that all ethical statements are literally meaningless. They do not express any facts at all; what they express is the speaker’s emotion.

9. Define moral relativism.

Ans. In modern times where world is in fact a global village there is no world consensus on which actions are right or wrong. If we consider how much moral views have changed both from place to place and age to age it can be held that there are no moral facts, but rather morality is always according to the society in which you have been brought up. This view is known as moral relativism.

10. What is naturalism?

Ans. Naturalism, in ethics is the view that moral terms, concepts, or properties are ultimately definable in terms of facts about the natural world, including facts about human beings, human nature, and human societies. As empirical facts contribute to make scientific theories similarly facts from social, psychological or cultural aspects of life can be used to make ethical theories.

11. What is deontological ethics?

Ans. In moral philosophy, deontological ethics is the normative ethical theory that the morality of an action should be based on whether that action itself is right or wrong under a series of rules and principles, rather than based on the consequences of the action. For example charity

is a moral action only and only if it is done because helping others through charity is a good thing.

12. What is a moral action according to Kant?

Ans. A moral action according to Kant is one that is performed out of sense of duty, rather than simply out of inclination or feeling or the possibility of some kind of gain for the person performing it. So for example if I am to give money to charity because of compassion for the needy, I am, in Kant's view, not acting morally.

13. 'ought implies can' explain in terms of Kant ethical ideas.

Ans. For Kant motive of an action is far more important than the action itself or its consequences. Kant believed that all people can be moral. Since we can only be reasonably held responsible for things over which we have some control, or as Kant puts it, since 'ought implies can' and because consequences of our actions are mostly beyond our control so these consequences can't be crucial to morality. For example in my attempt to save a drowning child if I consequently end up drowning him, my action will still be moral even with the tragic result.

14. What are hypothetical duties according to Kant?

Ans. According to Kant hypothetical duties are the ones that tell you what you ought or ought not to do if you want to achieve or avoid a certain goal. For example if you want to avoid going to prison that you ought to be honest in your dealings.

15. What are categorical imperatives?

Ans. According to Kant morality is a system of categorical imperatives. These are absolute, unconditional duties that are relevant for all cultures, nationalities and religions. For example 'you ought to always tell the truth' or 'you ought never to kill anyone'. The one important quality of these duties is that they are universal.

16. What are Maxims?

Ans. Kant describes the intentions or motives behind any action as the maxims. It is the general principle underlying an action. For example you can do good on the maxim that 'always help those in need if you expect to be rewarded for your action' or 'always help those in need if you want to feel happiness'. However your action will only be moral if you are acting on the maxim 'always help those in need because it is your duty

to do so'. so maxims can help us in determining whether our actions are moral or not.

17. What is meant by the principle of universalizability?

Ans. According to Kant the most basic categorical imperative is 'act only on the maxims which you can at the same time will to be universal laws'. In other words act only on maxims you would rationally want to apply to everybody. This is called principle of universalizability. For example 'one ought to always be honest' or 'do unto others as you want others to do unto you'.

18. Kant's ethical theory does not cope well with the conflicts of duties. Explain

Ans. A problem with Kant's theory is that it cannot easily cope with the conflict of duties. For example, I have a duty to always tell the truth and also a duty to always protect my friends. Now Kant's theory would not show me which duty to prefer if there is a conflict between them. Should I fulfil the duty and tell the truth when a murderer asks for my friends whereabouts or should I fulfil my duty and lie to protect my friend. There is no method to make a choice between the two.

19. Define utilitarianism?

Ans. Utilitarianism is one the most famous consequentialist theories. This theory is based on the assumption that the ultimate goal of all humanity is happiness. Good or a moral action will be the one that brings about the greatest total happiness.

20. Are hedonism and utilitarianism similar?

Ans. The underlying principle for both hedonism and utilitarianism is same and that is achievement of happiness. The difference is that Hedonism as a philosophy believes that one should maximize their own pleasure and minimize their own pain. on the other hand, Utilitarianism believes that morality is about creating the greatest happiness for the greatest number.

21. Utilitarianism deals with probable consequences. Explain.

Ans. Utilitarianism is an ethical theory that deal in probable consequences of an action. This is because it is usually, extremely difficult, if not impossible, to predict the precise result of any action. So a right action in any circumstance can be calculated by examining the

the probable consequences of various courses of action. Whichever brings about the most happiness or reduces the most unhappiness will be the right action.

22. What is negative utilitarianism?

Ans. The basic principle of negative utilitarianism is that the best action in any circumstances is the not the one which produces greatest balance of happiness over unhappiness but the one that produces the least overall amount of unhappiness.

23. What is rule utilitarianism?

Ans. Rule utilitarianism is a type of utilitarianism which rather than assessing the consequences of each action separately, adopt general rules about the kind of action which tend to produce greater happiness for greater number of people. For example if punishing the innocent produces more unhappiness than happiness, rule utilitarianism would adopt the rule 'never punish the innocent'.

24. Utilitarianism can end up justifying some immoral acts. Explain.

Ans. A very significant problem with utilitarianism is that it can lead to justification of immoral acts. For example from Bentham's point of view an addict is morally justified to do drugs because he can enhance his happiness with such drugs. Similarly it would be justified on his part to sell drugs in order to make money so that he satisfy his drug needs and thus get happiness.

25. To measure happiness is extremely difficult. Explain in terms of utilitarianism.

Ans. The most common objection put against utilitarianism is that it is extremely difficult to measure happiness and to compare happiness of different people. Mill tried to answer this objection by setting a distinction of higher and lower pleasures. By higher pleasure he means intellectual pursuit sand the lower pleasures are physical gratifications. However this justification can not be applied to the masses as most people don't engage in intellectual pursuits.

Long Questions.

1. Define ethics. What is its nature and scope?

Ans. Ethics is mainly known as the principle of moral conduct that makes a distinction between good and bad/ evil, right and wrong, virtue and non-virtue. The word ethics is derived from a Greek word 'ethos' meaning character. It is a branch of knowledge that governs right and wrong conducts and behaviour of an individual, profession, group or organization. It is a core of the professional and personal lives of people. Different scholars have defined ethics differently. However different their definitions might be, ethics is always concerned with morality and right vs wrong and good vs evil. It is applied universally. There is also ethics in professions such as journalism, advertising, education, medicine, etc.

There are 3 different **scopes of ethics**. They are:

1. **Meta-Ethics**
2. **Normative Ethics**
3. **Applied Ethics**

1. **Meta-Ethics:** Meta-ethics comprises the area of situational ethics and deals with logical questions like 'What do we mean by 'freedom' and 'determinism' etc. It delves into the nature of ethical properties, attitudes and judgments. For example, a media critic's description of a TV series as 'good drama' does not necessarily denote that the program is morally sound. It is the function of meta-ethics to define such vague concepts in ethical terms. Some of the theories of Meta-Ethics are Naturalism, Non-Naturalism, Emotivism and Prescriptivism.

2. **Normative Ethics:** this is the type of ethical theories that deal with standards or norms which can be used to judge human actions. For example, if someone murders a person everyone will agree that the action was wrong. Now the question arises that why is such an action considered wrong? This is the domain of the normative ethics to associate such a norm for the act of committing murder which can be universally acceptable. So we can say that murder is wrong because when we kill someone we violate their right to live. To make a norm following these elements are emphasized:

- The person who performs the act (the agent)
- The act

- The consequences of the act

3. Applied Ethics: Applied ethics is the problem-solving branch of moral philosophy. It uses the insights derived from meta-ethics and the general principles and rules of normative ethics in addressing specific ethical issues and cases in a professional, disciplinary or practical field. Applied ethics is the vital link between theory and practice, the real test of ethical decision-making. The scope of applied ethics ranges from political ethics, business ethics, environmental ethics to medical ethics and many other fields.

2. What is meant by the good?

Ans. Good

‘Right’ and ‘good’ are the two basic terms of moral evaluation. In general, something is ‘right’ if it is morally obligatory, whereas it is morally ‘good’ if it is worth having or doing and enhances the life of those who possess it.

Acts are often held to be morally right or wrong in respect of the action performed, but morally good or bad in virtue of their motive: it is right to help a person in distress, but good to do so from a sense of duty or sympathy, since no one can supposedly be obliged to do something (such as acting with a certain motive) which cannot be done at will.

There can be four types of distinctions among good actions as follows
Essential and Accidental, Real and Apparent, Perfective and Non-perfective and the last one is Perfect and Imperfect. Essential good are those actions that fit the natural needs of man as man. Such good include food, shelter, health, knowledge, virtue, and life. Accidental good actions, on the other hand are those that fit the wants of an individual because of his circumstance.

Real good is something which has an intrinsic value. Thus, we call it: Value. It possesses qualities rendering it “fitting” or desirable. -The real good includes both essential and accidental goods. Its opposite the Apparent good is actually an evil thing but is viewed as “good” under certain aspects. -Examples are diseases, sadness, death, worry, crimes, etc.

Perfective good action is that which contributes to the integral perfection of a person, such as: education, virtue, food, exercise, medicine. Non-Perfective good in contrast is that which merely contributes to the external appearance or convenience of a person, such as: clothes, wealth, social status, political power, etc.

This behaviour is evident in our concern for the best in everything: best friends, best parents, best food, best performance, best job and etc. According to many moral Philosophers, the greatest good is the Summum Bonum. For Aristotle, the greatest good is happiness. Happiness is what man aims to achieve in all his activities. The ultimate purpose of life is the attainment of happiness.

Naturally happiness is that which is attainable by man through the use of his natural powers. Natural happiness “consists in the perfection that can be attained by man through the employment of his body and soul and the powers inherent in them: intellect, will, internal and external sensory powers, the sense appetites, locomotion, nutrition and growth”

According to Aristotle, It was obvious that natural happiness does not rest on one single good object. Rather, it consists in the attainment of all those things that are essential to human growth and development. ☞ The highest good belongs to the intellect: the contemplation of truth. But this fullness of knowledge is attained through virtue.

No discussion of morals and good be completed without a religious aspect of it. Christian philosophers, St. Augustine and St. Thomas Aquinas taught that man, in every deliberate action acts toward an end, and ultimately, to an absolutely ultimate end: happiness. GOD- summum bonum -infinite good -the greatest good.

3. Briefly describe Deontological ethics./

Ans. Deontology is an ethical theory that says actions are good or bad according to a clear set of rules. Its name comes from the Greek word deon, meaning duty. Actions that are done following the rules are ethical, while actions that don't are not ethical.

The question that interested Kant the most was the question that what a moral action really is? It means that how do we ascribe moral value to

an action. For him a moral action was one performed out of sense of duty. Consequences cannot be enough to value an action because they are very hard to predict; considering moral actions are relative would end up blurring the lines of moral and immoral and emotions are usually subjective and so cannot be used as a standard for developing a universal code of conduct.

Hence the most reliable benchmark for any action to be considered moral or immoral can only be the motive or duty behind it. One is good because one is ought to be good. In explaining his ethical views Kant developed the idea that 'ought implies can' which means that everybody is capable of doing good. Kant favoured the development of universal motives or maxims as standards of moral actions.

Each maxim is a categorical duty that cannot be violated or bent in any circumstances. So in Kant's view if I am giving charity to a person because I have feeling of compassion then my action is not necessarily moral.

My charitable action will only be moral when I am acting under the maxim that "it is a duty to help a person in need". According to Kant the aim of our lives should be to act under a certain maxim, because motivations and intentions are somethings that can be easily gauged. An important aspect of maxims is that they can be universalized for there is no point in giving importance to a motive if it cannot be equally accepted by all the cultures, nations and societies of the world.

So 'always be honest' is a maxim everybody would want to act upon or 'do unto others as you want others to do unto you' can both be universalized and therefore are maxims according to one should act.

The biggest drawback of Kant's moral theory is that it can describe the structure and foundation of a moral act splendidly but it lacks the ability to guide people in their actions and help them make a choice. For example if we believe in maxims that 'always speak the truth' and 'always help your friend in need' and then we encounter a murderer asking for our friend's address, we will be in a dilemma about which maxim should we act upon.

4. What is the principle of utility? Explain utilitarianism as a flexible ethical theory.

Ans. Utilitarianism is the best type of consequentialist theory based on the assumption that the ultimate aim of all human activity is happiness. A utilitarian defines good as 'whatever brings about the greatest total happiness'. This is also known as the principle of utility.

According to the principle of utility the right action in any circumstance would be calculated by examining the probable consequences of different courses of actions. Whichever is likely to bring about the most happiness is the right action in those circumstances.

An important aspect of utilitarianism is that it has to deal with the probable consequences as it is usually extremely difficult to predict precise results of any particular action. This aspect of utilitarianism becomes one of its flaws because in order to establish the moral worth of an action we need to be certain about it.

Similarly we don't have any standards for comparing happiness produced by different actions as well as actions of different people. For example execution of a captured soldier would bring happiness to one country but sadness to a neighbouring one. So how to determine if the action is right or wrong.

A further objection to utilitarianism is that it is quite flexible in the sense that it can justify many actions which are usually thought immoral. For example publicly hanging someone would act as a deterrent by reducing the acts of violent crimes. Even if the person was proven innocent later on, the action causes more happiness for more people because of reduced crime rate and so the action of publicly hanging a person would be a morally right thing to do.